

IT IS A SUNDAY NIGHT in San Francisco and Sundar Pichai is all set for a chat. As CEO of Alphabet Inc. and its subsidiary, Google, he runs a business with \$258 billion in revenues. However, it's not all work for this 50-year-old cricket buff as he laments India's exit at the Men's T20 World Cup 2022 in Australia. He reiterates that nothing will stop him from being in India for the ICC Men's Cricket World Cup 2023. "I plan to be there," he quips. In an exclusive interview over Google Meet with *Business Today's* Sourav Majumdar and Krishna Gopalan, Pichai speaks candidly on a host of issues related to Search, Cloud, technological disruption, YouTube, regulation and, of course, India. Edited excerpts:

42 | ▶▶▶

We are in a VUCA world and this is coupled with a possible global economic crisis. How do you see this scenario playing out from your perspective?

It is an extraordinary time of uncertainty and I think the focus from central banks in handling both inflation and rising interest rates defines it to some extent. Like any other large global company, we are dependent on GDP growth and there is obviously caution. From my standpoint, you need to focus on things that are in your control. That means looking at our core priorities and approaching our work more efficiently.

That said, we must make sure our products are working, including what we offer to our advertisers, since they are trying to be more efficient with their spends. In moments like these, the strength of Search is important in terms of being more effective as a product. Over time, we are also investing in AI to make some of our products work even better for

advertisers. It really comes down to making it simpler and in line with their budgets.

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On digital, there is a lot that is going on with immersive technologies globally, be it the metaverse, AR and VR. In that backdrop, how do you see the Web 3.0 story playing out?

As Google, we definitely think about AR. It is no different from how we have evolved from mobile and living today in a multi-device ecosystem, with watches, tablets and so on... One day, when computing can augment what we are doing, we may not always need to use our phone. Therefore, we definitely see potential in AR and are investing for that.

Last year, we saw Google Glass and the immersive view in Maps or multi-search—all these mean we are building for a world where we are working not just with a phone in mind but also laying the foundation for an AR world. We are also looking at how Android can support AR. I see AR as a natural extension and evolution of computing. There will be use cases with Glasses and some infor-

Google has been a cloud native company from day one. Below that is AI, which will create new opportunities over time

mation on it and that is easier than the AR/VR experience.

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Are we close to Glass in an immersive format?

The objective is to have a more immersive experience but it will take a bit of time. In fact, it will be a few years before it [Glass] goes mainstream and we are helping prepare the ecosystem for that.

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What are your thoughts around innovation in a VUCA world that is prone to disruption?

As a technology company, it's important to work through these moments well since constant innovation is necessary. For example, a lot of progress has been made on AI. Or there is a lot of excitement on large language models and we are investing in all these areas as well—both, for us to improve our products like Search and YouTube and also through Cloud to bring it to our partners. Therefore, I am, in some ways, focussed on how we as a company can invest in some of these new areas, when overall we are constrained in terms of how we can invest. That means we will need to reprioritise and free up enough resources where we can, and put them into our most important projects. Those are the kind of trade-offs we need to do. We are absolutely committed to innovating in this space—we have been an AI-first company for a while and we are very focussed on this.

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What will be the key growth drivers for Google globally and in India?

Globally, when we speak of giving access to information and knowledge, we still think these are early days. With AI, we will continue to build